

CHINESE TAIPEI

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Language and Literacy

Mandarin Chinese is the official language of Taiwan, as well as the language of instruction for most subjects at all school levels. Other local languages include Taiwanese, Hakka, and aboriginal languages. Students from Grades 1 to 6 are required to study one local language spoken in Taiwan. Beginning in third grade, English is obligatory as well. High schools offer additional optional foreign language courses.¹

As evidence of Taiwan's emphasis on literacy, several initiatives have been implemented to promote reading and literacy. For example, the Ministry of Education in 2000 introduced the National Children's Reading Project to emphasize the importance of reading development and children's literature. Private sectors including the Taiwan Reading and Culture Foundation initiated the Philanthropic Library, which provides books for group reading in schools.² Additionally, the Hsin-Yi Foundation introduced the Bookstart program in public libraries for children up to 3 years old.³ In 2011, the Ministry of Education began promoting Bookstart activities for all first grade students and set up a teacher in-service training program focused on reading instruction.⁴

Overview of the Education System

The government of Taiwan has adopted a centralized educational administration system that specifies national standards for curricula and national level assessment (e.g., use of the Comprehensive Assessment Program results for senior high school placement and college entrance examinations). All schools in Taiwan adhere to the national curriculum standards, use approved textbooks, and prepare students to pass college entrance examinations.

The education system in Taiwan encompasses basic, intermediate, advanced, and returning education. Basic education includes kindergarten, primary school, and junior high school. Intermediate education includes senior high school and vocational education. Advanced education includes junior college, university, and graduate school. Returning education refers to schools for continuing and supplementary education. Special education is provided at all levels for students with physical and mental disabilities.

Since 1968, a nine year compulsory education program for basic education (primary and junior high school) has been in place, with basic education divided into three levels: Level One (Grades 1 to 3), Level

Two (Grades 4 to 6), and Level Three (Grades 7 to 9). Children begin Grade 1 when they turn age 6. In 2015, Taiwan's basic education was extended from 9 to 12 years to include senior high school. A new curriculum is being developed for implementation in 2018.⁵

Senior high schools and senior vocational schools provide intermediate education above the junior high school level, both requiring three years to complete. Students at the senior high school level take courses that prepare them for a college or university education. Senior vocational schools offer courses in areas such as agriculture, industry, business, marine products, nursing, home economics, drama, and art.

Junior colleges fall into two categories: five year junior colleges and two year junior colleges. Five year junior colleges admit junior high school graduates, while two year junior colleges admit senior vocational high school graduates. University programs typically require four years of study; however, students have the flexibility to fulfill their requirements in three to six years. Specialized undergraduate programs (e.g., dentistry and medicine) require six to seven years of study, including a one year internship period. Graduate programs leading to a master's or doctoral degree require one to four years and two to seven years, respectively. Students entering graduate school as part of on the job training may be granted an extension if they are unable to finish the required courses or complete their thesis or dissertation in time.

Returning education provides citizens with an alternative means of achieving their educational goals. Returning education is classified into three main categories: basic education, advanced study, and short term supplementary education. A wide variety of courses is offered in returning education, involving different levels of difficulty and varying in duration according to the individual curriculum. Returning education courses include literacy education, cooking, pottery, flower arrangement, economics, Chinese or Western philosophy, and psychology.

In addition to compulsory education, most of Taiwan's young children attend kindergarten and daycare programs, around 60 percent of which are privately owned. To ensure that every child receives proper care and education, financial support for preprimary education is available from the government for 5-year-old children.

Language/Reading Curriculum in the Fourth Grade

Reading Policy

A clear statement of Taiwan's reading policy is included in the *General Guidelines of Grade 1–9 Curriculum*, published and implemented in 2003 and revised in 2011 by the Ministry of Education.⁶ The curriculum's section on language includes guidelines for instruction of Mandarin Chinese, other Chinese dialects, and English. Because Mandarin Chinese is the language of testing for PIRLS in Taiwan, the following summary presents a description of the Chinese reading curriculum.

Summary of National Curriculum

The Chinese reading curriculum contains general goals for students' academic attainment and requirements for the three levels of basic education, as well as guidelines for reading materials and instruction. The goal of reading instruction in primary grades is to cultivate students' abilities to use the Chinese language. Students are expected to listen, speak, read, and write effectively in order to think, comprehend, reason, coordinate, participate in discussions, appreciate, and create. Moreover, students should be motivated to read extensively, to appreciate literature and Chinese culture, and to use the Internet and other tools for independent learning.

Generally, students in Grades 4 to 6 are expected to develop the strategies they will need to learn from reading. Goals for these students include the following:

- Be familiar with the orthographies, sounds, and meanings of new words and use them flexibly
- Distinguish between the styles of spoken and written classical Chinese
- Form a habit of reading extracurricular books
- Regulate reading strategies to promote reading speed and efficiency
- Understand the main ideas and structure of texts
- Have a general understanding of grammar and rhetoric
- Recognize basic stylistic features of texts
- Master reading strategies for different kinds of texts
- Understand the tone and feeling of texts
- Search for information in the library to enhance self-learning
- Use reference books to gain independent problem solving abilities
- Learn to compile, abstract, and organize information
- Have a general understanding of different types of text and be able to use words and structures that are contextually appropriate
- Enjoy words and voices that communicate and express different things in different contexts
- Discuss the content of readings and share thoughts with others
- Understand expressions of respect for people, things, and objects
- Cultivate the spirit of group participation by engaging in reading activities that enhance interactions
- Read classical and modern literature from China, Taiwan, and foreign sources
- Connect reading materials to the real world
- Apply knowledge of organizational structures (e.g., sequential, causal, contrast) to reading

- Use computers and other technology to enhance language ability
- Read attentively and be mindful of details
- Read content thoroughly and develop thoughts broadly
- Grasp the process of problem solving in texts
- Think critically about the content of texts

Teachers, Teacher Education, and Professional Development

In 1994, the Teacher Education Act deregulated teacher education. This enabled all universities and teacher colleges to establish teacher education programs in order to produce K–12 teachers. A 2005 amendment to the Teacher Education Act required teacher colleges to transform into education universities and provide the same teacher education programs as regular universities.

Prospective elementary school teachers must have a college degree with up to 40 credits from a teacher education program. The 40-credit-hour program for primary school teacher education includes course requirements in each of the following areas: education foundations (e.g., educational psychology, philosophy, and sociology); general methods (e.g., principles of counseling, testing, and measurement); teaching methods (e.g., nature and social science); and basic subject content (e.g., children’s literature, general mathematics, and science). Upon completion of the program, primary school teachers are expected to be able to teach any subject when necessary.

Following graduation, prospective teachers participate in a one semester supervised practicum at a school, after which they must take a national written qualification examination. Once they pass the examination, new teachers are eligible to interview for employment. The Bureau of Education in each regional government is responsible for recruiting teachers for local schools. The Bureau forms a committee composed of college professors, school administrators, teachers, parents, and local government personnel to select teachers.⁷

Requirements for Ongoing Professional Development in Reading for Teachers

Teachers are required to participate in in-service training for a certain number of credit hours each year that varies across schools and districts. Each school arranges its own training program for its teachers; alternatively, teachers may attend seminars and workshops related to their own interests and needs. After each seminar or workshop, participants receive a statement of credits earned. Following PIRLS 2006, more reading instruction-related workshops became available for primary school teachers. This is described in detail in the Use and Impact of PIRLS section.

Reading Instruction in the Primary Grades

The *General Guidelines of Grade 1–9 Curriculum* lists the following guidelines for effective practices for teachers:⁸

- Reading is the center of language instruction; however, reading should be learned in conjunction with listening, speaking, composition, and writing
- Student-centered instruction of comprehension strategies should be considered in order to cultivate independent reading abilities
- Teaching a text should begin with an overall review, followed by a paragraph by paragraph analysis to understand the content in depth, and then a study of the format, rhetoric, structure, characteristics, and style of the text
- Comprehension strategies for various types of texts taking into consideration students' background knowledge should be provided

Generally, teachers of Chinese adhere closely to the textbooks and workbooks, teaching all content therein. In teaching Chinese, most teachers follow a set of procedures and use instructional activities that comply with textbooks and workbooks. For example, lessons in first grade always begin with a warm-up activity, mostly through choral reading or questioning, that reviews previous lessons and previews the next lesson. This is followed by a variety of activities that consolidate learning and concludes with desk work. While teaching procedures used during and after third grade are similar, lessons at these levels use more extended and integrated activities. For example, activities such as brainstorming and dramatization are used to reinforce the lexical or linguistic focus of the lesson or to elaborate on the text.⁹

In fourth grade, approximately 60 percent of classroom time is focused on character instruction and practice.¹⁰ A common method of classroom instruction is for the teacher to write a character on the blackboard and ask students to trace the character in the air.¹¹ Many teachers believe that students will not be able to understand texts without proper instruction on Chinese characters. However, research indicates that from second grade on, students read by the unit of word, not by character.¹²

Instructional Materials

Taiwan's national curriculum standard requires schools to follow regulations for selecting instructional materials for students. In general, publishers develop Chinese textbooks based on the *General Guidelines of Grade 1–9 Curriculum*. A committee formed by the Ministry of Education examines these books and releases a list of approved textbooks. Schools then form a textbook selection committee including teachers, administrators, parents, and subject specialists to choose appropriate texts from this list. Many teachers also use library materials for extracurricular reading and student assignments.

Use of Technology

Almost all primary schools have computer laboratories or computers in the classrooms, and teachers are asked to integrate technology into classroom instruction. Students are required to take computer literacy classes and often are assigned tasks that require them to search for and read information on the Internet.¹³

Second Language Instruction

As mentioned previously, students begin learning English as a Second Language in third grade. Therefore, qualified English teachers are in great demand. The Ministry of Education provides subsidies to schools that hire qualified foreign teachers who speak English, especially in disadvantaged areas.

Students with Reading Difficulties

Taiwan's *Special Education Law*, introduced in 1984 and revised in 1997, mandates that schools offer special education programs and medical doctors or therapists to provide diagnoses and treatment or rehabilitation for students with special needs. The law ensures that special education services are provided for students with learning disabilities, including reading difficulties.

Diagnostic Testing

Students with reading difficulties are identified by regular classroom teachers or parents. Once identified, these students are evaluated by trained special education teachers in their school district or by clinical psychologists at hospitals. Following a diagnosis with a learning disability, a student is observed for one year to confirm that “general instruction from regular education” cannot improve the student's reading. However, the major problem with Taiwan's criteria for learning disabilities is the lack of an operational definition of “general instruction from regular education.” Even with a confirmed diagnosis, few effective evidence-based programs exist for students with learning disabilities or reading difficulties.¹⁴

Instruction for Children with Reading Difficulties

Students identified as having learning disabilities are eligible for various special education services, such as collaborative consultation or co-teaching in their regular classroom and special education resource rooms. In most cases, students remaining in regular classrooms are sent to resource classrooms periodically to reinforce the material being taught.

Monitoring Student Progress in Reading

In Grades 1 to 9, student progress is evaluated twice in each grade, and parents are sent a report card at the end of each semester. Some schools have a schoolwide examination for each subject at each grade level, but the classroom teacher is responsible for evaluating students.

In 2004, the Ministry of Education launched the Taiwan Assessment of Student Achievement (TASA) program to determine whether the education goals outlined in the *General Guidelines of Grade 1–9 Curriculum* have been met. TASA is a nationwide assessment taken by students in Grades 4, 6, 8, and 11. The subjects tested include Chinese, mathematics, science, social studies, and English. All participating students are required to complete questionnaires regarding their personal and family backgrounds. The Ministry of Education plans to use TASA results to create a database for the study

of Taiwanese students' progress and the education system. In addition, many regional governments have created remedial programs for low achievers (Percentile Rank <35 in the class) in Chinese and mathematics to ensure that basic skills are learned by every student.

Special Reading Initiatives

Besides the Ministry of Education's National Children's Reading Project, which aims to emphasize the importance of reading development and children's literature; the Philanthropic Library, which provides books for group reading in schools; and the Bookstart program for children up to age 3 and all first grade students, teacher in-service training on reading instruction was held throughout the country after PIRLS 2006. Please refer to the following section on Use and Impact of PIRLS.

Use and Impact of PIRLS

Taiwan first participated in PIRLS in 2006. Following the release of the PIRLS 2006 results in 2007, a national report and a pamphlet summary of PIRLS 2006 were distributed among teachers and parents. A consensus was then reached that no true reading instruction was being provided in classrooms. The Ministry of Education has realized that most Chinese language teachers are not familiar with reading instruction. As a result, national reading centers have been established in universities across Taiwan to develop reading instruction models and instructional materials. In 2015, junior high school teachers were included in this reading instruction training program.¹⁵

The regional government has sponsored many reading instruction workshops for teachers, focusing on topics such as the international definitions and criteria of reading literacy. Some teachers have become aware that reading is more than decoding, and that students need more comprehension strategies to help them integrate and synthesize what they read. Some teachers have begun to model the question types used in PIRLS and to ask questions about multiple perspectives in their Chinese language classes.

Suggested Readings

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